

Pitch D v2.1 — The Listener

Revised per showrunner notes of 10 July 2026 · supersedes the Pitch D page of episode-1-pitches-v2.pdf

CHANGES IN V2.1

① The implausible "breathing on the call" is gone. The final message now has *no words in it* — Dot deliberately recorded her intruder onto the show's voicemail line. She is smart and brave, not oblivious; the audio is plausible (a mic aimed on purpose); the hook is stronger. ② Marnie Kowalczyk → **Dot Ellis** ("Dot from Rivermouth"). ③ All radio grammar removed. The show is a podcast with a **listener voicemail tip line** — Ally reads the number at the end of every episode; Dot's weekly messages arrive after each episode drops, and Ally sometimes plays them on air. The "radio still on" discovery is replaced: **the coin is left on Dot's phone-charger cradle**. The tip line becomes a permanent series institution.

"Her last message to the show has no words in it. Forty seconds of someone else in her house."

LOGLINE

Ally's podcast ends every episode the same way: she reads out the tip-line number and says *tell me what this city won't*. For three years the last voicemail after every episode has been Dot from Rivermouth — a widow in a riverside cottage who signs off, every week, *say goodnight to the harbour for me, Ally*. Eleven days ago Dot left a different kind of message: 3:04 a.m., forty seconds, no words. A floorboard. The spring of a back door. A diesel engine ticking in the lane. It sat unheard in the queue for three days while Ally made a show about listening. Now Dot has vanished, the messages Ally once played on air may be the reason, and to find a woman she never asked a single question, Ally must reconstruct an entire life from three years of voicemail.

THE VICTIM & THE DETAIL

Dot Ellis, 72 — widow, insomniac, riverside cottage in Rivermouth, one estranged sister, no one else. The detail: *"say goodnight to the harbour for me, Ally"* — the sign-off on three years of weekly voicemails. The player hears it once in the cold open and the episode's final scene pays it off.

THE KEEPER

Ally carries this one — the guilt engine is that the show was the only family Dot had, the show sometimes played her messages for colour, and the show never asked her surname. Her distress call waited three days in a voicemail queue. Every lead the player completes audibly rebuilds Dot from her own recordings: a street, a routine, a sister, a name. The player is assembling the person nobody bothered to know — including, at first, Ally.

THE SECRET

Dot's cottage overlooks the Rivermouth reach, and her rambling weekly messages — some of which Ally aired as the show's warm closing minute — occasionally mentioned "the quiet boats" that pass below her window with no lights. Someone whose boats those are finally heard one. A man visited her house twice: once as a

"gas inspector" nobody scheduled (checking her sightlines), once at 3 a.m. — the visit Dot recorded. He was never there to hurt her; he was there to establish what she could see and mark the house handled. Dot, sharper than anyone credits, fled that night to the estranged sister she was too proud to call for thirty years — telling no one, because apart from a voicemail line, there was no one. When Ally reaches the empty cottage, the marker is waiting where he knew she'd look: a coin, placed on the phone-charger cradle in the hall. He knew the phone was how Dot talked to her.

REVEAL LADDER

1. The forty seconds, cleaned and separated (the player's first evidence work): a floorboard twice, a door-spring, a diesel tick — and a hitch in the footsteps. He's real. He limps.
2. Three years of voicemails as an evidence corpus: her street reconstructed from ambient sound — gulls, a school bell, and a low bridge note Gerald names in one listen (the Rivermouth swing-bridge). The show finds her house from her own goodnight messages.
3. The cottage: mail piled, kettle cold, phone charger empty — and the coin on the cradle. (*planted, unexplained*)
4. The neighbour's doorbell camera: the "gas inspector," ten days before. Nobody official scheduled him. He walks with a hitch. Same man — and he came in daylight first.
5. **Midpoint inversion — the motive is the show.** The aired messages. "The quiet boats." Dot was targeted because Ally broadcast her window. Jeopardy lands on Ally: whoever listened to Dot has heard every episode — including the one Ally is making right now.
6. Climax: pharmacy scripts, a parish newsletter, a bus timetable — the trail Ally builds from voicemail crumbs ends at a hill cottage and an estranged sister, and Dot, alive: furious at the fuss, holding the door open before Ally knocks.

THE BRANCH (PHASE 2)

Air the forty seconds. Put the intruder's own footsteps on the show — ten thousand ears might place the diesel, the limp, the door — but he learns exactly what Ally has, and that she's coming. **Or hold them back** — Del Cruz's ask — and hunt quietly while a frightened woman stays missing a day longer and the queue fills with false sightings. Both paths converge at the sister's cottage; the choice changes one Phase 2 scene and one line of the finale, and flags the player's instinct for the season: loud truth or quiet truth.

GERALD'S ENGINEERED ENTRANCE

Ally brings the cleaned audio to the Anchor expecting comfort. Gerald puts on the headphones, and where anyone else would wince at footsteps in an old woman's house, he *turns the volume up*. Thirty seconds pass. "Swing-bridge counterweight. Rivermouth reach — the old crossing sings when boats run late." Then, quietly, he keeps the headphones on and listens to the whole forty seconds twice more, making notes with a pencil. One scene, three facts learned by feel: he was a detective, he is precise, and he will sit with the frightening thing so Ally doesn't sit with it alone. Attachment built, not assumed.

DOCTRINE SCORECARD

Dramatic question ≤2 nodes

Node 2: forty seconds, no words. Unwalkable-away-from, and now sniff-test clean.

Ally warmth beat (L1–L2)

She noticed one silent regular among thousands — and says goodnight to the harbour herself, on the show, in case Dot can hear it wherever she is.

Ally competence beat (L1–L2)	L2, on-page: she separates the forty seconds into a map — floorboard, door-spring, diesel, and the hitch in the steps. "He's real. He limps."
Grievable victim, one detail	"Say goodnight to the harbour for me, Ally" — now compounded by her competence: she recorded her own intruder rather than panic.
Engineered entrances	Gerald: the volume-up scene. Del Cruz: enters declining a misper for "an adult who stopped leaving voicemails" — then runs the doorbell footage anyway, off the record. Mo: pours, listens, says "Dot Ellis. Used to clean the school on Chandler Street" — the Anchor knows everyone the city forgot.
Jeopardy on Ally by midpoint	Reveal 5: the show itself is the reason. He has heard every episode. He knows her sign-off as well as Dot's.
Vulnerability beat	Ally alone, locket open, the night before the hills: her father knew the name of every stranger he ever quoted. She built a show on voices and monetised one woman's loneliness for a closing segment. Is this the show he'd have made?
Guided tour	L2 processes the forty seconds (evidence), L3 processes the archive (data) — merge output audibly converts into cleaned audio and mapped streets. The engine is the case.
Effort engine	Each lead restores a piece of Dot out loud — a street, a school, a sister, a surname. The player assembles a person from a voice, and the show says each new fact like an apology.
Whiff of change + coin	The coin on the charger cradle, never explained. Change: Ally ends the pilot knowing the show has one listener she never wanted — and keeps broadcasting anyway. Final-line register: "He listens. Good. Then he heard me say I don't scare."

CANON & NEW FACES

Rivermouth Industrial (riverside cottages, the swing-bridge), the Rusty Anchor (Gerald's scene; Mo's one-line city-memory), Del Cruz (Harbor Ward pragmatism, off the record), Kestrel Point fog on the drive to the hills. The "quiet boats" and the coin quietly seed Episode 2's open question — where the route lands was visible from Dot's window all along. New portraits: Dot (one unforgettable face), her sister, the doorbell-camera neighbour.

THE RESOLUTION BEAT

The episode has always ended the same way: Ally reads out the tip-line number. This one ends differently. A fresh voicemail in the queue, played on air, timestamped an hour before release: *"It's Dot. You found an old woman who didn't want a fuss, and you made one anyway. Good girl. Say goodnight to the harbour for me."* — "Goodnight, Dot. Goodnight, harbour." The episode's first detail becomes its final line, said at last by both of them.

OPENING — L1 · "THE TIP LINE" (PODCAST, VO)

SPEAKER	EMOTION	LINE
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1	Ally	neutral	My show has a voicemail line. End of every episode I read the number out and say: tell me what this city won't. Mostly it's theories. Sometimes it's lonely people. For three years, the last message after every episode has been Dot from Rivermouth — and every one ends the same way. Say goodnight to the harbour for me, Ally.
2	Ally	worried	Eleven days ago, Dot left a different kind of message. Thursday. Four minutes past three in the morning. Forty seconds long. There are no words in it.
3	Ally	sad	Forty seconds of a house not being empty. A floorboard, twice. The spring of her back door. And no scream, no call to her sister, no police — she pointed her phone at the dark and sent it to the one number she trusted. It waited in my queue for three days. I was busy making a show about listening.
4	Ally	neutral	Dot, if you can hear this: goodnight, the harbour misses you. Everyone else — this is Echoes of Havenbay. The tip line is open. This week, it's mine to answer.